Aegidius de Murino — Tractatus cantus mensurabilis (14th century)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Master Aegidius de Murino, a fourteenth-century master of music known by one thing only, the name at the head of this treatise, *Magistri Aegidii de Murino*. No chronicle records his birth, his town beyond the name Murino, his pupils, or his grave, and none is invented here. His book is his only monument; its closing explicit is the whole of his epitaph. He ended with the proverb that for the wise and understanding, few words suffice, written, he said, for the instruction of little ones.

The author's own terms

Color and *colorare* — a *color* is the repeating rhythmic pattern laid over a tenor; to color is to lay the tenor out in that pattern, and “do not break the color” means do not spoil it. *Talea* — the repeating rhythmic shape. *Ordinare* — to ordain, or order: to arrange the tenor's notes in measured lengths. *Apertum* and *clausum* — the “open” and “closed” cadence-endings of the repeated song forms.

The story

The story that can honestly be told is the work's story: the name itself is the record. Scholars have tentatively identified the treatise's author with Egidius de Francia, a mid-14th-century French theorist possibly an Augustinian friar at Santo Spirito in Florence and possibly the Chantilly Codex composer Egidius; every step of the identification is conjectural, and the folder's record — a name at a treatise's head — is all that is certain. The attribution is itself a live question: a reviewer of Margaret Bent's *The Motet in the Late Middle Ages* records that Bent suggests that the treatise should be considered "Anonymous." Motet-writing treatises also circulate as *De motettis componendis* and *De modo componendi*; whether those titles name this text was not resolved against an incipit in this run. Reaney's *Grove Music Online* entry on him (2001) exists, but was not opened — a named gap, not a source read.

The work and what survives

The treatise is a workshop manual, not a speculative treatise. Take a chant tenor from the antiphoner. Ordain and color it in perfect mode, three or six *tempora* to the note, or imperfect, two or four. Build contratenor, triplum, and the motet voice over it. Divide and diminish the tenor, with repeats signed, ordain rests that never break the color, and fit the words in four parts. An alternate construction, with the tenor above, rises to five voices: "and so the motet will be totally full." It closes with the ballade and rondellus forms. The Latin stands in Coussemaker, volume 3 (Paris, 1864), pages 124 to 128 — five printed pages, one continuous lesson with no chapter breaks. The folder holds a complete plain-English rendering of the whole printed text, from the Latin as read in the Thesaurus Musicarum Latinarum transcription, entry AEGTRA_TEXT. Its tenor examples are described in words, not drawn, and the edition's spelling scars are left visible.

Its English fortunes

No complete English translation of Aegidius de Murino's *Tractatus cantus mensurabilis* was found after research; the Latin stands in Coussemaker, vol. 3, pp. 124–128.

That finding is bounded. The searches behind it, run on 17 October 2026, used both name spellings, Aegidius and Egidius, and all three title forms named

above. No WorldCat sweep was run, Reaney's Grove entry was not opened, and the modern discussion literature was not page-checked for embedded passage renderings, which, if any exist, would narrow the finding at passage level only. The page 125 passage traced in this run is quoted in Latin, not Englished, in Pirrotta's essays.

What completing it would take

Nothing is missing from the slice itself: the folder renders the whole of Coussemaker's five-page text, and states plainly that the rendering is a draft not yet given the final checks required before public use, including an independent Latin collation at this desk. Completing it would take settling the title question against an incipit; opening Reaney's Grove entry and Bent's opening chapters at first strength, so the attribution language rests on the scholarship itself, not on review summaries; verifying that transcription against Coussemaker's page images, the folder's verification having run through a provisional mirror during an outage; and a passage-level check of the motet literature, including Bent and *Hearing the Motet*, before any stronger English wording is used.

Sources

- Project folder: ~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/aegidius-de-murino-tractatus/aegidius-de-murino-tractatus.txt (Coussemaker, vol. 3, pp. 124–128)
- PIN: ~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-aegidius.md
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Egidius_de_Francia
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Egidius_(Chantilly_Codex_composer)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_medieval_music_theorists (Reaney, Grove, 2001, citation; entry not opened)
- https://www.thefreelibrary.com/
  The+Motet+in+the+Late+Middle+Ages.-a0836743374
- https://ebin.pub/essays-on-italian-poetry-and-music-in-the-renaissance-13501600-reprint-2020nbsped-9780520329966.html